

NYU GSAS DEPARTMENT OF MUSIC CONFERENCE

OCT 2-3 2026

distortions

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Welcome

New York University's GSAS Department of Music warmly welcomes you to our 2026 graduate student conference:



**Silver Center for Arts and Sciences
October 2-3, 2026**

The term *distortion* is derived from the Latin *dis*, meaning apart or away, and *torquere*, meaning to twist. It refers to the bending, warping, or deformation of an object's shape and/or form. In a sonic context, *distortion* is used to describe the alteration of an audio signal or wave. It is often characterized by a harsh, gritty sound. Through the amplification of what are generally considered imperfections, errors, or failures, *distortion* performs an array of functions: it interrogates, confuses, vulgarizes, disrupts, alienates, subverts. At the same time, scrubbing a recording of its so-called imperfections also involves a warping of sonic materials; attempting to rid an object of *distortion* only distorts further. *Distortion* can be weaponized by the powerful, just as it can function as a tool of resistance, liberation, and imagining. This conference explores *distortion* and its various overlapping contexts: sonic, political, metaphysical, aesthetic, literary, bodily, legal, and more.

Our program is comprised of contributions from various scholars and performers whose work engages with (but are certainly not limited to) topics and themes such as:

- distortion, overdrive, grain, synthesis, noise, static, interference;
- warping, bending, spirals, fractals, plasticity, deformation;
- disinformation, misinformation, fascism, propaganda, censorship, post-truth, conspiracy;
- fraud, fakes, forgery, bootlegging, piracy, artificiality, streaming manipulation;
- failure, corruption, glitch, mutation, transformation, translation, disruption;
- alternate realities, queer temporalities, liminality, non-place, time, space, simulation
- speculative fiction, sonic fiction, critical fabulation, futurities;
- para-sociality, circulation, cybernetics, artificial intelligence;
- superstition, urban legend, (media) folklore;
- techno-doping, surgery, biohacking;
- trauma, mental health, ghosts, haunting, vertigo, disorientation, neurodivergence and masking;
- alternate tunings, DIY instruments/music spaces, hacking, auditory illusions.

We are delighted to be hosting this event and look forward to the thoughtful engagement of our presenters, keynotes, and attendees. Thank you for sharing this enriching weekend with us!

Land Acknowledgement

Land and territory acknowledgements have become increasingly performed at academic gatherings. They often fulfil a box-checking function to justify or ease guilt, rather than to truly acknowledge and honor the people, treaty agreements, and unseeded lands of Turtle Island. We wish to use this land acknowledgement to intentionally and thoughtfully reflect on the purpose of these statements, understanding that this practice extends beyond a simple recognition. Our intention today, as we acknowledge this land and its customary keepers, is to encourage a sustained, individual, and collective effort, rooted in reflection and action.

New York University rests over Mannahatta in Lenapehoking. We acknowledge that we are gathering over the ancestral and traditional homelands of the Lenape, Canarsie, Wappinger, and other Indigenous groups, who have been displaced by settler colonialism. We extend our deepest respect and gratitude to the First Nations and Metis communities—past, present, and future—whose lands we occupy. We recognize the ways in which our presence here, upholds colonialism and reproduces dispossession and violence for Indigenous communities.

In coming together as scholars and creatives for the GSAS Department of Music's Distortions Conference, we actively reflect ourselves, as well as our systems, institutions, and creative landscapes. We remain committed to respecting and learning how to honor and uphold this land and its ancestors. We actively reflect on the roles of these systems and spaces we occupy, recognizing them as powerful tools for decolonization, reflection, action, care, and healing.

Note to Sponsors

This academic and artistic event was made possible by our sponsors, to which we are grateful for their support:

- NYU FAS Department of Music
- The American Musicological Society
- The Public Humanities Initiative in Graduate Education at NYU
- Dean Lynne Kiorpes and the Dean's Office of the Graduate School of Arts and Science
- Dean Elizabeth McHenry and the NYU Dean's Office for the Humanities
- XE: The Experimental Humanities & Social Engagement Department at NYU Gallatin
- The Music Theory Group at NYU

Schedule

Friday, October 2, 2026	
8:00 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.	Registration (Silver 120)
8:00 a.m. – 9:00 a.m.	Breakfast (Silver 120) (Breakfast and coffee provided)
9:00 a.m. – 9:15 a.m.	Introductory Remarks (Silver 320)
9:00 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.	Ongoing Installation (Silver 120) Bria Nachele, <i>Bridge Over Troubled Waters / Still Watters Run Deep</i>
9:15 a.m. – 10:45 a.m.	Panel 1: Refracting Queerness and Femininity (Silver 320) Chair: Maureen Mahon - Jaida Wilson, “‘I Wanna Take You Out Sometime’: ‘Sushi’ and Black Queer Nightlife in Eusexua” - Stella Seorin Bak, “Distorting Femininity in K-POP across Borders: The Transnational Reconfiguration of Body Image in TWICE” - Gillian Radcliffe, “Timbral Expressions of Gender and Sexuality in SOPHIE’S ‘OIL OF EVERY PEARL’S UN-INSIDES’ (2017)”
11:00 a.m. – 12:30 p.m.	Panel 2: Temporal Mediations (Silver 320) Chair: Jaime Oliver - Yanqi Chen, “Mediated Duration: Technical Memory, Cybernetic Operability, and the Distortion of Time” - Julian Day, “‘At Least I’ll Live As I Believe’: Peering Through the Dark Shades of ‘Pop Star Time’” - Lauren Adamow, “She(’s) Got A()way: Temporal Drag in Chappell Roan’s ‘The Subway’”
12:30 p.m. – 1:30 p.m. *1:00 p.m.	Lunch (Silver 120) (Catered lunch provided) - Screening: Sawyer Adler, <i>The Sunset Scrolls: An Opera for TikTok</i> (10 min)
1:30 p.m. – 3:15 p.m.	Concert 1 (Silver 220) - JD Davids, Moira Williams, Forest Kameran, <i>Care on Hold: Pharmacy Hold Music, Access Intimacy, and the Sonic Politics of Chronic Illness</i> - Thessia Machado and Ranjit Bhatnagar, <i>slipgear</i>

	• Lisa Ann Schonberg and Sara Wentworth, <i>Mount Right</i> • Federico Balducci, <i>Dial Drift v3: System Signal Residue</i>
3:30 p.m. – 5:00 p.m.	Panel 3: Warping Space (Silver 320) Chair: Fanny Gribenski • Sophia Cocozza, “Distorting the Environment: Carolee Schneemann and the Sound of Collision” • Jenn Grossman, “Tracing the Blur: Exploring Reverb’s Psycho-Spatial Resonance” • Jessie Monts, “Knowing after Postmodernism: Ecological Imaginings of Spatio-Temporal Epistemology in Jessie Montgomery’s Rounds”
5:15 p.m. – 6:45 p.m.	Panel 4: Distorted Vitalities (Silver 320) Chair: Clifton Boyd • Seon Shim, “Distortions in the Brain: QEEG Brain Mapping in Neurodivergence Diagnosis” • Ian Mahanpour, “‘The Digital Revolution is Over’: Oval, Mille Plateaux, and the Silence of Madness” • Max Keller, “Halted Voices: AIDS Testimony in the K. Robert Schwarz Papers”
7:00 – 8:00 p.m.	Keynote Performance: Ka Baird (Silver 220)
8:00 – 9:00 p.m.	Reception (Silver 220) • (Catered food provided)

Saturday, October 3, 2026	
8:00 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.	Registration (Silver 120)
8:00 a.m. – 9:00 a.m.	Breakfast (Silver 120) • (Breakfast and coffee provided)
9:00 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.	Ongoing Installation (Silver 120) • Bria Nachele, <i>Bridge Over Troubled Waters / Still Watters Run Deep</i>
9:00 a.m. – 10:30 a.m.	Panel 5: Paranormal Presences (Silver 320) Chair: Annie Garlid

	• Isobel D’Cruz Barnes, “Hearing Things: Haunted Acoustemology and the Sound of Supernatural in Post-Colonial Malaysia” • DB Amorin, “Interference Events: UAP and the Mythogenic Field” • Liz Jorgenson, “Digital Ghosts in the Analog Machine: Technological Failure, Sampling Loops, and Echoes of the COVID-19 Pandemic in Alex Kister’s <i>The Mandela Catalogue</i>”
10:45 a.m. – 12:15 p.m.	Panel 6: Audio Interference (Silver 320) Chair: Joshua Biggs • Alex Durr, “It’s Like You’re Really There: Liveness and/as Fidelity in Recordings of Independent Origin” • Isaac Blumfield, “The Speed of Samples: Audio Playback Speed as (Artistic) Research” • Mike Clemow, “Audi Pro Nobis: Field Recording, Dysmorphia, and the Post-commodity Condition”
12:15 p.m. – 1:15 p.m.	Lunch (Silver 120) • (Catered lunch provided)
1:15 p.m. – 2:45 p.m.	Panel 7: Twisting Narratives and Semiotics (Silver 320) Chair: David Samuels • Jarden Gertler-Jaffe, “Chronotopes of Jewish Persona in Bates’ <i>Kavalier and Clay</i>” • Ellen Jeon, “IMDb Sorting Algorithms and the Semiotics of Audience Voice in <i>Squid Game</i>” • Zachary Walker-Kahne, “The False Promise of Music in Dorothy Baker’s <i>Young Man with a Horn</i> (1938) and Michael Ondaatje’s <i>Coming Through Slaughter</i> (1976)”
3:00 p.m. – 4:00 p.m.	Panel 8: Political Spirals (Silver 320) Chair: Louis Karchin • Lydia Rufin, “Dancing With the Devil: Music and Dance as Indicators of Social Inversion in Images of the Witches’ Sabbath in Early Modern Europe” • Winter Craig, “Satanic Seal of Approval: The Parental Advisory Label’s Religious-Right Backmasking Scare Origins and Role in Democratic Campaign Strategies”
4:15 p.m. – 5:45 p.m.	Concert 2 (Silver 220) • Alma Laprida and Bryce Hackford, <i>Subwoofer Duo</i> • Alexandra Berger and Allen Fogelsanger, <i>Static</i> • David Acevedo, <i>NANO I</i> • Laura Horne, <i>To Which Do We Belong</i>

6:00 p.m. – 7:30 p.m.	Keynote Talk: Mara Mills (Silver 320)
7:30 p.m. – 8:30 p.m.	Reception and Closing Remarks (Silver 220) • (Catered food provided)

Abstracts and Program Notes

Friday October 2

Panel #1: Refracting Queerness and Femininity

Chair: Maureen Mahon

(9:15 a.m. – 10:45 a.m., Silver 320)

Jaida Wilson

Cornell University

“I Wanna Take You Out Sometime’: ‘Sushi’ and Black Queer Nightlife in Eusexua”

In a series of albums all released in 2025, English singer, songwriter, producer, and dancer FKA Twigs offers audiences the concept of *eusexua*, defining the term as a “practice,” “state of being,” and “the pinnacle of human experience”. This paper chooses to key in on the track “Sushi” from *Eusexua: Afterglow*, the third album in the series which chronicles the feeling of “leav[ing] the rave in search of your next wonder”. Engaging with work from queer theorists and black queer performance scholars, I argue that, in addition to showing examples of queer intimacy and utopia within quotidian date suggestions, “Sushi” signals the experience of a black queer night out through its soundworld. The relatively crawling pace that characterizes the first half of the track affords a methodology of slowness to listeners, allowing for a mellowed movement that is essential for the survival of many black queer women under the duress of neoliberalism, capitalism, and gentrification in their neighborhoods. But the second half walks the listener out of the nightclub into the world of vogue ballroom through the sonic hallmarks of the crash cymbal, the commentator, and a number of samples. In having this ballroom-centric version of the song be the official release—as opposed to an alternative version which fans begged for—“Sushi” discourses specifically with notions of quare (black and queer) temporality and subjectivity. In doing so, Twigs confirms that, as an album, term, and feeling, *Eusexua* can be a reference point for discussing the often overlooked temporal complexities of the black queer nightlife experience.

Stella Seorin Bak

New York University

“Distorting Femininity in K-POP across Borders: The Transnational Reconfiguration of Body Image in TWICE”

This study investigates how femininity and the female body are translated, reconfigured, and distorted through transnational media flows, focusing on the K-pop girl group TWICE. While global media circulation is often understood in terms of cultural translation or adaptation, this paper argues that these processes also produce forms of distortion, in which meanings are not simply transferred but reshaped, intensified, and made to function differently across contexts.

As K-pop continues its global expansion, female idols must navigate divergent feminist discourses across markets. South Korea's cultural landscape is largely shaped by feminist backlash and what may be characterized as a “politics of silence,” whereas the United States operates within postfeminist and neoliberal frameworks that privilege confidence, visibility, and individual

empowerment as dominant ideals. Drawing on a comparative qualitative analysis of six music videos produced for Korean and U.S. markets, this study examines five analytical dimensions: lyrics, mise-en-scène, styling, choreography, and camera work.

The findings indicate a discernible shift in how femininity is constructed across these markets. Korean-oriented content tends to present a restrained, narrative-driven femininity, whereas U.S.-oriented productions foreground bodily visibility, direct self-expression, and a performance centered femininity. Rather than marking a linear progression toward liberation, this shift reveals how feminist discourse is distorted through neoliberal media logics: the language of empowerment is amplified yet simultaneously tied to intensified bodily display and commodification.

This study contends that the female body functions as a central site of cultural translation, one through which feminist discourse is selectively appropriated and reshaped according to the demands of each market context. This study contributes to transnational media studies and feminist cultural theory by reframing translation as a process that produces transformation and distortion and highlighting how global media flows reshape, rather than simply transmit, gendered meanings.

Gillian Radcliffe

Florida State University

“Timbral Expressions of Gender and Sexuality in SOPHIE’S ‘OIL OF EVERY PEARL’S UN-INSIDES’ (2017)”

Over the past ten years, a new genre of music has started to emerge in the popular music industry labeled as “hyperpop”. This genre expands the cis-heteronormative expectations of popular music, which are typically upheld by a societal expectation of sound (timbre) and lyric content that favours heteronormative and cisgender identities. In contrast, hyperpop expands expressions of gender expression by signaling queerness to listeners through the use of distortion, computerized sounds, Auto-Tune, etc. By adopting the work of Pecknold (2016), I argue that the “teen girl” voice has evolved into something otherworldly/futuristic, resulting in a machine-like or cyborg sounding voice in popular music, commonly appearing in hyperpop.

This paper adopts the work of Nobile (2022) and Spreadborough (2022) to analyze persona and narrative throughout SOPHIE’s 2017 album, *OIL OF EVERY PEARL’S UN-INSIDES*. I suggest three additions to Nobile’s original six (Speech-song, Modal, Belt, Soft voice, Sweet voice, Squeal) vocal styles: Teen Girl (Pecknold 2016), Mechanical, and Cyborg. The “mechanical” voice is defined as an amplification/warping of vocal fry, while the “cyborg” voice is defined as a mix of the “teen girl” and “mechanical,” resulting in the otherworldly timbres associated with hyperpop. I further draw on charts used by Barna and McLaughlin (2024), and Allen Moore (2009), to show the differentiation between the personas portrayed by the singers and their vocal timbre within songs. For example, in “Faceshopping,” I argue that two personas are portrayed, the “consumer” and the “industry.” SOPHIE’s voice acts as the industry, represented by the “mechanical” voice. Cecile Believe takes the role of consumer, represented by the “modal/cyborg” voice. The song’s use of consumer/industry personas results in a commentary on our heteropatriarchal society. By using the consumer’s voice to taunt the industry, we hear a construction of femininity that exists outside of our current society.

Panel #2: Temporal Mediations

Chair: Jaime Oliver

(11:00 a.m. – 12:30 p.m., Silver 320)

Yanqi Chen

Columbia University

“Mediated Duration: Technical Memory, Cybernetic Operationality, and the Distortion of Time”

Distortion is often defined as alteration, twisting, or misrepresentation, whether as a technical glitch, an aesthetic deviation, or a nonlinear phenomenon in audio feedback and visual processing. This paper argues that distortion is not merely accidental noise or formal deviation, but an essential feature of media’s ontological status as a temporal modulator. Through an examination of contemporary music composition and multidisciplinary performance, this study demonstrates how such modulation functions as the primary mechanism for restructuring temporal experience

The first section establishes a philosophical framework grounded in Bernard Stiegler’s revision of Husserl and Bergson. Utilizing the concept of "tertiary retention," the inquiry illustrates how technologies do not merely store memory but actively format and discipline the flow of vital duration. Alvin Lucier’s *I Am Sitting in a Room* (1969) serves as a seminal case study, wherein recursive audio feedback loops generate a temporal distortion that transforms the audience’s perception of speech into a rhythmic, technical ambience.

The second section addresses operational media and the cybernetic regulation of time. Within the logic of Digital Audio Workstations and interactive systems such as Max/MSP, time is dissected into granular, optimizable parameters. Through an analysis of Ryoji Ikeda’s *datamatics [ver. 2.0]*, it is argued that the elimination of human-centric spontaneity creates a "persistent present." In this context, composition is redefined as the construction of a self-optimizing system that enforces a relentless, quantized continuity.

Finally, the paper contrasts traditional "commodities of time"—characterized by the linear consumption of orchestral music—with contemporary multidisciplinary performance. Through the works of Pamela Z and Ash Fure, the text explores how voice processing and gesture-sensing controllers explicitly map digital architecture. This distortion of time replaces physical capital with multi-sensory feedback, requiring the audience to navigate a negotiated, active reality. Ultimately, this structural reconfiguration enables both composer and audience to maintain subjective agency, transforming the technical apparatus from a tool of capital consumption into a shared site of critical subjectivity.

Julian Day

Yale University

“‘At Least I’ll Live As I Believe’: Peering Through the Dark Shades of ‘Pop Star Time’”

As if on cue, the final months of a turbulent century yielded one final artistic controversy. On the face of it, there was little on the 1999 album *My Beauty* to stir the blood, just a set of covers of vintage pop by Bacharach, Lennon and McCartney. The trigger was the face fixed on the viewer,

that of a prematurely balding West Country man wearing lipstick, suspenders and a string of pearls. As one reviewer put it, “seldom in the history of music has a record been so overshadowed by the controversy surrounding its cover art.”

Kevin Rowland had last been seen on 1980s magazine covers and TV after his band Dexys Midnight Runners’ *Come On Eileen* improbably stopped Michael Jackson from earning back-to-back number one hits. Then – a decade and half’s silence. *My Beauty* was Rowland’s long-awaited comeback but it confounded the UK’s newly laddish public who could not parse a middle-aged transgender man singing hoary love songs. The UK’s venal press swirled rumors of Rowland being pelted off stages with full beer bottles.

Hidden to the detractors was that Rowland had been dumped by the music industry’s invidious rollercoaster and had spent the previous eleven years addicted to heroin and living in squats. His attempt to reenter public life was fatally compromised by his destabilizing of gender, confirming Judith Butler claim that “performing one’s gender wrong initiates a set of punishments both obvious and indirect.” This paper argues that Rowland’s career emblemizes a ‘pop star temporality,’ a warping of Erik Erikson’s immutable eight-stage life cycle here entwined with William S. Burroughs’ similarly bleak “junkie time.” In contrast to standard expectations of how one’s life should unfold, pop artists are commonly left in a perpetual twilight of inertia with a surplus of time left to live.

Lauren Adamow

University of Pittsburgh

“She(’s) Got A()way: Temporal Drag in Chappell Roan’s ‘The Subway’”

Chappell Roan’s “The Subway” is a multimedia exploration of queer temporality, disorientation, and post-breakup grief. Incorporating theories of queer time by José Esteban Muñoz, Sara Ahmed, and Judith Butler, as well as Stan Hawkins’s work on temporality in pop music, Roan constructs a form of “temporal drag” through visual, sonic, and spatial strategies that distort linear, normative understandings of time.

The music video situates the subway as a liminal space where time is both hyper-regulated and suspended, mirroring the cyclical and disorienting experience of heartbreak. Roan’s exaggerated hair, refusal to “move on,” and repeated lyrical phrases create a sense of being trapped between past and present, while sensory triggers – such as glimpses of a former lover or familiar scents – collapse temporal boundaries. Not only does she drag time in a queer sense, but is also dragged in a temporal and physical sense.

Musically, the track’s use of 1980s-inspired synthesizers produce a nostalgic yet unstable sonic landscape, blurring distinctions between past and present while destabilizing the listener’s sense of temporal grounding. Shifts in musical texture, particularly between dense choruses and stripped-down post-choruses, further fracture linear progression and suggest multiple coexisting temporalities.

“The Subway” enacts queer temporality not only as a thematic concern but as an embodied, affective experience for both performer and audience. By refusing resolution or reorientation, Roan’s work positions disorientation itself as a productive site for understanding grief, desire, and the persistence of the past within the present.

Concert #1

(1:30 p.m. – 3:15 p.m., Silver 220)

JD Davids, Moira Williams, Forest Kameran

Care on Hold: Pharmacy Hold Music, Access Intimacy, and the Sonic Politics of Chronic Illness

This paper-performance explores collaborative distortion for articulating the embodied, affective, and political experiences of chronic illness and disability in late-stage capitalist US, with several interconnected audio works created by three members of the Sick Music Center and featured in Blood Songs + Oracles Crip Careoke collective karaoke song writing workshops and exhibition at MacKenzie Art Gallery, SK, Canada, with an accessible lounge facilitated and designed by moira williams. The work centers access intimacy collective music making, and disability justice frameworks to demonstrate how sonic distortion can reveal truths otherwise silenced or obscured by medical and bureaucratic systems.

The first work samples On Hold, recorded by JD Davis during his calls with pharmacies and benefits providers—the sonic infrastructure of medical-industrial gatekeeping. With composition and additional vocals by forest kameran, sound direction and video design by moira williams. The piece transforms the alienating experience of administrative delay into a moment of collective testimony, giving literal voice to the challenges faced by disabled chronically ill people ("ilders").

The second work presents a reading of "I Took A Pill," a poem from the Cranky Queer digital newsletter. The work has a flat exhausted affect and applied audio effects that emphasize the visceral experience of medication, family gender care, and myriad delays.

Both pieces engage what Mara Mills and disability justice scholars describe as the politics of listening and sonic accessibility. By foregrounding distortion—typically coded as error, noise, or failure—as a legitimate mode of expression and knowledge-production, the work refuses demands for "clarity" or "improvement" from ableist culture. Distortion becomes a practice of resistance and access intimacy between performers and audience.

This paper-performance is situated within a lineage of disability justice music-making, including the December 2025 Sick Music Center concert, at Recess Arts, NYC, which centered musicians and listeners with chronic illness and disability as knowledge holders. It asks what possibilities emerge when we center access intimacy as both aesthetic and political practice.

Thessia Machado and Ranjit Bhatnagar

slipgear

slipgear is an improvisatory performance duo. We work with handmade electronic and acoustic instruments and let the materials guide the development of the music. We tend towards a drone-noise sort of sound, as the video demonstrates. We like to make our homemade instruments legible to the audience, and approachable - we encourage the audience to try them out after the performance.

In the set-up for this performance, the concept of distortion is embodied in a couple of different ways: one of the instruments used is a monochord mounted on a flexible board that can be bent during playing to produce pitch bends and tremolo effects. The distortion here is quite physical/material. The other main instrument is a set of 6 clusters of 3 tuned LED lights (forming

6 chords) that are read by light sensors. Distortion here is presented by the manipulation of the light sensors and the use of motors to rhythmically interrupt the beams of light, creating variations in timbre and rhythmic patterns.

There is also use of pedal effects, loops, and an assortment of objects and small devices. The magnetic fields produced by some of these devices, and by the audio gear itself, such as mixers and power supplies, can be auscultated and sonified by using pick up coils, bringing these normally inaudible frequencies to our hearing range.

Lisa Ann Schonberg and Sara Wentworth

Mount Right

Mount Right is a live performance project by a duo of viola and drums with electronics, grounded in the sound of the Adirondack peak Wright Mountain. A score for improvisation is based on the composers' experience on this mountain, where signals to cell phones are distorted and sensory reception of sounds originating on the peak is heightened. In the electronic composition, the recordings of the water, wind, and soil on the mountain are filtered, presented as fragmented spectra. The performers' interactions with each other and the recordings are personal reactions to sound across space and time, using loops and delay to build on memories of affect and embodiment. Are mountaintops what remains of refuges from our cellular entrapments?

Federico Balducci

Dial Drift v3: System Signal Residue

Dial Drift v3 is a 20-minute graphic score for two LFO-driven synthesizers, electric guitar, and DTMF tone generator (telephone signaling system). The work explores communication as a fragile, unstable system—moving from emergence and interference to partial synchronization, fragmentation, and eventual dissolution.

The score is structured across five sections: Activation, Interference, Lock/Decode, Fragmentation, and After/Residue. Performers navigate a shared visual language of waveforms, symbols, and numeric signals, using proportional time rather than fixed meter. The DTMF layer functions as both sonic material and control system: numeric tones act as triggers, while symbols (*, #, 0) introduce behavioral shifts such as synchronization, inversion, or stasis.

Rather than prescribing exact pitches or rhythms, the piece emphasizes relational listening and system-based interaction. At key moments, performers must reduce, destabilize, or reinterpret their material in response to the DTMF layer and each other. Misinterpretation is built into the structure, allowing the ensemble to oscillate between coherence and breakdown.

As the piece progresses, density peaks and then collapses into fragmentation, where signals become incomplete and gestures decay. Finally, the "after" phase presents a ghostly version of the system, consisted of residual tones, sparse events, and almost silence; this phase ends only when the system has ceased to function completely.

Dial Drift v3 sits between composition and improvisation, drawing on traditions of graphic notation while incorporating contemporary concerns with networks, signaling, and technological failure.

Panel #3: Warping Space

Chair: Fanny Gribenski

(3:30 p.m. – 5:00 p.m., Silver 320)

Sophia Coccozza

University of Pennsylvania

“Distorting the Environment: Carolee Schneemann and the Sound of Collision”

In 1962, Carolee Schneemann collaged the interior of the Living Theatre with broken glass, mirrors, burlap, and “sound making lumps,” constructing an environment in which any movement—by performer or audience—risked becoming audible consequence. Across works such as *Glass Environment for Sound and Motion* (1962) and *Noise Bodies* (1965), Schneemann develops a practice in which sound emerges not from composed musical structures, but from friction, collision, instability, and bodily contact.

This paper argues that Schneemann’s early environments produce distortion as a condition of listening. Sound is generated through interference: scraping surfaces, shifting materials, bodies brushing, falling, and colliding in space. Rather than presenting distortion as an effect applied to sound, these works embed distortion within the material and spatial conditions of the environment itself. Listening becomes disoriented, distributed, and contingent—shaped by proximity, movement, and the unpredictable interactions between bodies and objects.

Drawing on archival materials from the Getty Research Institute—including Schneemann’s notes, sketches, and installation documentation—I reconstruct how sound producing materials and spatial arrangements were designed to produce sensory instability. These works stage what might be understood as a distorted sensorium, in which vision fragments, sound diffuses, and the boundaries between body and environment blur.

Engaging sound studies and theories of embodiment, I show how Schneemann’s practice reframes distortion not as error or failure, but as a generative aesthetic and political condition. By foregrounding noise, instability, and bodily vulnerability, her work challenges normative models of perception and reimagines listening as an embodied, multisensory, and relational encounter.

Jenn Grossman

New York University

“Tracing the Blur: Exploring the Affective Potentials of Reverberation’s Psycho-Spatial Resonance”

This paper/sonic presentation will look from a creative, affective and ontological perspective at reverberation for its ability to extend, modify, blend, and connect, its transportive and transcendent spatial qualities, and its mind-altering mental affects. While signaling what kind of “literal” space we’re in; a cave, a small room, or large church, less looked at; reverberation can also signal “imagined”, or “other-worldly” spaces. This work will pool perspectives in phenomenology, queer phenomenology, affect theory, sensory studies, psycho-acoustics and perception, sound studies, music, film/media studies, and technology, referencing theorists/musicians like Annie Goh, Michel Chion, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, Pauline Oliveros, Steve Goodman, Janet Cardiff, Johnathan Sterne, Sara Ahmed, Vangelis, Susan Philipz, Budhaditya Chattopadhyay, Antoine Gaudin and David Roche, amongst others, as well as

reference ambient music, “space” music, soundtracks, and architectural spaces, to consider how this simple audio phenomenon can move us beyond its technical capacity as an audio “effect”, into a compositional and artistic tool. Also metaphysical in nature, through its dimensionality, reverberation merges space with consciousness, pulling us into the blurry areas and the between spaces, to feel presence, but also distance, to ground but also disorient us, depicting sounds’ past, future, and present selves. Focusing on reverberation as an embodied phenomenon experienced from the perspective of listeners, this work explores literal and metaphoric reflections, the creation of felt dream-like environments, ambiances, atmospheres, and sound spaces, which expand or shift our sense of time and place, allow us to time-travel or transport us to other-worlds.

Jessie Monts

Eastman School of Music

“Knowing after Postmodernism: Ecological Imaginings of Spatio-Temporal Epistemology in Jessie Montgomery’s *Rounds*”

Postmodern conceptions of spatio-temporal epistemology have often been postulated in relation to twentieth-century discoveries in quantum physics and general relativity, as in Karen Barad’s “Troubling Time/s and Ecologies of Nothingness: Re-turning, Re-membling, and Facing the Incalculable.” These scientific advancements have led to radical collapses of space and time, engendering the postmodern paradigm of thought wherein knowledge is inherently relative, situationally determined, and unstable. This format of spatio-temporal epistemology is inherently anthropocentric, a position that poses immediate and pressing threats to the global environment. The dissolution of truth and the primacy of individual experience under this structure can be tied to the recent surge in political conspiracy, and particularly for this study, climate change denial. One proposed response to the ongoing climate crisis (exemplified by the Deep Ecology movement, among others) is to shift away from anthropocentrism and towards ecological posthumanism, wherein the environment is prioritized through epistemologically de-centering humanity. Music holds significant potential for creating inroads to new and alternative ontologies through processes of pre-reflective phenomenology and bodily mimesis, as postulated by Juha Torvinen and Susanna Välimäki, and Arnie Cox. Jessie Montgomery’s 2022 composition *Rounds* provides an opportunity to experience an ecologically-grounded paradigm of time, space, and knowledge that responds productively to decaying and destructive threads of postmodern thought. Montgomery’s use of concentric rondos and organic fractals in the conceptualization of her piece invites an experience of time and space that is neither linear nor irreparably fragmented, but repetitious and cyclically embedded. These musical elements actualize ecological space and time, which cycles across broad scales and is unbounded by human perspectives, experiences, and manipulations. Through Montgomery’s explicit exploration of ecological themes, a musical experience emerges that can provide synthesized realities of a new paradigm of spatio-temporal epistemology, one which may be necessary to reverse the ongoing climate crisis.

Panel #4: Distorted Vitalities

Chair: Clifton Boyd

(5:15 p.m. – 6:45 p.m., Silver 320)

Seon Shim

University of British Columbia

“Distortions in the Brain: QEEG Brain Mapping in Neurodivergence Diagnosis”

Tracey Moffatt, an Indigenous photographer and filmmaker, distrusts the immediately visible. She deliberately distorts images in pre-production and works from memory rather than direct observation, making art that foregrounds intention over surface appearance. Her practice unsettles “reality”: is distortion a departure from the real, or a truer record of thought and desire?

This paper turns that question toward the neurodivergent bodymind navigating institutional evidentiary regimes. Its central scene is a QEEG brain map—produced in Korean, translated into English, and made legible for North American disability bureaucracies before embodied testimony could be heard. Drawing on Johannes Fabian’s notion of allochronism and Brian Hochman’s genealogy of recording technologies as tools of “savage preservation,” the paper argues that the scan’s authority is a double fiction: it appears to capture something timeless, yet media designed to secure one knowledge system are themselves fragile and already decaying at the moment of inscription. The QEEG does not document a body; it pre-processes one. Family histories of *han* (Kim) remain off the record. Charles Briggs’s concept of biocommunicability extends this argument: medical discourse scripts who counts as a credible speaker, in which genres, and through which instruments.

Reading the scan through Gloria Anzaldúa’s borderlands, the paper situates a Korean neurodivergent subject shuttling between incompatible regimes of legibility—Korean familial obligation and North American disability bureaucracy—each demanding different forms and languages of self-translation. Threaded through is *nadaenda*, the injunction against standing out, reframed as transnational pre-processing: an internalized demand to shrink and retune one’s bodymind before entering the clinic or the office, a culturally specific mode of neurodivergent masking that eludes, and thus exceeds, the scan’s visual field.

The paper closes by returning to Moffatt, proposing distortion-as-method as a crip epistemology: making from memory rather than from what is “seen,” refusing the clinic’s documentary, archival, and pathologizing impulses, and insisting that the bodymind appear on its own terms. In this sense, if the scan “translates” the body into data, the paper translates back, re-situating evidence within lived, relational, and contested memory.

Ian Mahanpour

University of California, Berkeley

“‘The Digital Revolution is Over’: Oval, Mille Plateaux, and the Silence of Madness”

“The digital revolution is over.” Glitch artist Kim Cascone foregrounded his influential essay “The Aesthetics of Failure” (2000) with this declaration, borrowed from a 1998 text by Nicholas Negroponte, who argued that the everyday ubiquity of digital technologies signaled that their most transformative effects had already taken place. While Negroponte framed this post-revolutionary period as a moment of positive integration, Cascone instead interpreted it as “post-

digital” self-criticality. For Cascone, the emergence of musical glitch practices in the 1990s signaled a shift away from unreflective technological consumption toward a critical self-awareness of its illusory utopian promises.

The contribution of this paper is to extend the concept of the post-digital by returning to Cascone’s original formulation and situating it through a fresh analysis of Markus Popp (Oval), a key pioneer of glitch aesthetics. Challenging interpretations that align Oval with avant-garde “cracked media” or microsound traditions, I argue that Popp’s work is more productively understood in relation to his home label Mille Plateaux. In particular, Popp’s contributions to the Mille Plateaux compilation *In Memoriam Gilles Deleuze* (1996) are widely recognized as foundational to post-digital music, yet remain insufficiently situated in relation to Popp and label head Achim Szepanski’s idiosyncratic engagements with poststructural theory.

Thus, I develop a framework that positions Popp’s music as operating through two interrelated metaphors: music as software and madness as technique. By deliberately misusing CD technologies, Popp reconfigures the relationship between technological protocols and irrationality, framing their interaction as a form of non-antagonistic “disobedience” toward corporate digital culture. In this sense, the post-digital names not only a critical awareness of technology, but also a method for producing such awareness: an engagement with the radical alterity of madness. I conclude by reflecting on the implications of this framework for post-digital studies and the historiography of electronic music.

Max Keller

CUNY Graduate Center

“Halted Voices: AIDS Testimony in the K. Robert Schwarz Papers”

This paper looks to the K. Robert Schwarz Papers at Queens College as an underexamined archive of musical AIDS testimony, focusing on a December 1992 taped interview between musicologist-journalist K. Robert Schwarz and baritone William Parker of the *AIDS Quilt Songbook* (1993). This interview, which took place just before Parker’s AIDS-related death, would inform Schwarz’s *Out* profile of Parker titled “The Gift of Song” (1993), and his articles on AIDS and classical music for the *Times* and *American Record Guide*.

At the top of Schwarz’s interview transcript appears a handwritten description of Parker’s AIDS-ravaged voice: “Voice halting, soft, clearing throat, needing to stop for air, imbued a wistful poignancy.” This paper analyzes Schwarz’s vocal description — as well as Parker’s recorded singing in the *Songbook* — through the lens of Roland Barthes’s “grain of the voice” as reinterpreted by disability scholars Laurie Stras and Jessica Schwartz: How does the voice “bear witness” to trauma?

Hindsight renders the Schwarz-Parker interview more poignant: Seven years after conducting the interview, Schwarz himself died of AIDS. His papers — recorded interviews, typed transcripts and drafts, handwritten edits — show the labor of relistening and rewriting. With such implied repetitions, the Schwarz-Parker interview becomes itself like a piece of Minimalist music, recalling tape-based works like Steve Reich’s *Different Trains*, about which Schwarz wrote in *Minimalists* (1996). Like Reich, Schwarz crafts what Amy Lynn Wlodarski calls “musical testimony” from voices.

Ultimately, I read the Schwarz-Parker interview as “reciprocal testimony” for reporter and subject. The recording captures both Parker’s voice and Schwarz’s active listening, with Schwarz’s

questions shaped by his own sense of mortality. Building upon Andrea Zarafshon Moore's work on music and memorialization, and Will Robin's on Schwarz and Minimalism, this paper positions Schwarz as an understudied figure in queer public musicology, arguing for his archive's importance to AIDS remembrance.

Saturday October 3

Panel #5: Paranormal Presences

Chair: Annie Garlid

(9:00 a.m. – 10:30 a.m., Silver 320)

Isobel D'Cruz Barnes

University of Pennsylvania

“Hearing Things: Haunted Acoustemology and the Sound of Supernatural in Post-Colonial Malaysia”

Hantu (ghosts, spirits and/or demons in the Malay language) occupy an important place in Malaysian traditional belief and contemporary popular culture alike. From Malaysia’s significant production of *pontianak* (female vampire-ghost) films to infamous real-life instances of demon-induced mass hysteria in young women and girls, *hantu* have also come to represent Malaysia internationally, on and off the screen. However, the State’s decreasing tolerance of its own traditional cultures post-independence, particularly in light of years of corruption, deception and scandal at the federal level, has led to a profound distortion and disruption of Malaysian national identity amongst its multicultural populace. This paper connects the changing role of spirit entities in postcolonial Malaysia with shifting local attitudes toward music and sound, situating the links between traditional belief and musical life within the country’s fraught political landscape. I explore how music and sound are still today used to summon, negotiate and repel *hantu* as well as what these entities “sound like” to modern Malaysians—following anthropologists such as Aihwa Ong and Emily Ng in taking ghosts seriously as an object of research. Indeed, while spirit possession, folklore, and belief in the supernatural are well documented in anthropological texts on Malaysia, and representations of such entities are an emerging topic in screen, media, and film studies, scholarship focused on music and sound in this area is relatively scarce. Working across texts in music and sound studies, hauntology, screen studies and folklore studies, I use ethnographic data collected in two fieldwork periods in 2025 to discuss the place of *hantu* in contemporary Malaysia. Through conversations with Malaysian musicians in both traditional (*mak yong*, *wayang kulit*) and popular music contexts, I argue that attitudes toward *hantu* are inextricably linked to music and sound’s subjugated and heavily-regulated place in modern Malaysian society.

DB Amorin

Independent

“Interference Events: UAP and the Mythogenic Field”

This performative-lecture utilizes concepts around noise and glitch aesthetics, applying them to the topic of Unidentified Anomalous Phenomenon (UAP) to expand our understanding. Rather than locating reports of anomalous phenomena within a materialist, object-oriented paradigm, this presentation proposes viewing such sightings as interference events, artifacts emerging at the limits of perception and interpretation. Citing the works of interdisciplinary thinkers such as Jacques Vallée, Donald Hoffman, Bernardo Kastrup, D.W. Pasulka and Terence McKenna, the presentation establishes UAP within a broader conceptual framework I refer to as

the *mythogenic field*, a speculative model in which reality is (de)stabilized through a moiré of shared perceptual and narrative structures, with anomalous phenomena emerging at the boundaries of these intersections.

Error or failure here is approached as a generative function, an interruption in an established communication system between reality and its participant-observers that exposes how meaning is constructed. In these occurrences, the event becomes an aperture through which underlying structures of what we perceive to be relevant become momentarily visible. A long history of cross-cultural accounts, from those documented by psychiatrist John Mack to long-established indigenous cosmologies studied by professor Ardy Sixkiller Clarke, expose knowledge systems that record these experiences as events arising from perceptual edge conditions. The resulting ontological shock propagates outward, often reshaping collective understanding and expanding symbolic limits.

Combining experimental lecture, signal manipulation, and audiovisual material, this talk draws parallels between signal distortion and anomalous events, suggesting both help define the boundaries of the systems that produce them. If perception operates as a filtering mechanism, then these events may be understood as an emergent property of a wider system making itself known. By reframing UAP as meaningful distortions rather than simply aberrant external objects, the presentation asks: what if the glitch is an important, structural feature of a co-produced reality?

Liz Jorgenson

University of Pittsburgh

“Digital Ghosts in the Analog Machine: Technological Failure, Sampling Loops, and Echoes of the COVID-19 Pandemic in Alex Kister’s *The Mandela Catalogue*”

Alex Kister’s ongoing YouTube series, *The Mandela Catalogue*, is an example of a new style of horror filmmaking called analog horror, which seeks to replicate the visual and sonic aesthetics of analog media. One of the most striking aspects of this series is the sound design. Throughout *The Mandela Catalogue*, Kister aims to replicate the decay of analog media over time, as well as the manipulation of this media by the supernatural, through audiovisual glitches. These moments of technological failure mark the most visceral moments within *The Mandela Catalogue*, and I argue that these glitches, and the sampling methods used in creating them, reflect tensions of the early 2020s, particularly of the Covid-19 pandemic.

Drawing upon literature on supernatural presence in media by Jeffery Sconce and Marc Olivier, as well as mimesis theory by René Girard and Nidesh Lawtoo, I examine the tensions inherent to the digitally-created glitches in *The Mandela Catalogue*, and I argue that the resulting sounds of failure create a sense of undead presence lurking within the media object itself. Although these sounds typically signify an organic breakdown of technology, the digital sampling processes used to create the sounds of this breakdown evoke a sense of mechanized eternity. These aesthetics evoke the fears prevalent during the pandemic, including those of bodily infiltration via virus and the repetitive spread of misinformation on social media. With this study, I argue that production is just as much part of the horror as narrative, particularly on the level of sound design.

Panel #6: Audio Interference

Chair: Joshua Biggs

(10:45 a.m. – 12:15 p.m., Silver 320)

Alex Durr

Eastman School of Music

“It’s Like You’re Really There: Liveness and/as Fidelity in Recordings of Independent Origin”

By its nature, recordings of live concerts from independent origins, often known as “bootlegs,” represent an alternate stream of recording techniques and distribution channels compared to recordings made by the rights owners of the musical material. With this, varying notions of what a “good bootleg recording” is, its characteristics, and its presentation are negotiated by various different actors at all stages of production, often with widely different values. This becomes more complex when considering the audiences of these independent recordings, who often are producers of such recordings as well. In observing discussions about different recordings of independent origin, I find that the capture of an authentic live experience emerges as aesthetically more important than a recording being high fidelity, and easily digestible. Building off Jonathan Sterne’s assertion that fidelity, a recording’s ability to accurately replicate a sound, is a socially formed notion and not objectively found, I establish the various aesthetic preferences for different kinds of bootleg recordings. In this paper, I argue that values of fidelity are negotiated in ways completely different from officially released recordings, dependent on intention from those preparing the recording for wider distribution, and the audiences engaging with such recordings. Using several different recordings of independent origin and discussions from online circles for bootleg recordings, I show how notions of fidelity and liveness emerge from the discourses around bootleg recordings. Liveness, a recording’s ability to capture the feeling of being at a concert, emerges as a prioritized attribute in these recordings, often at the expense of traditional fidelity. In effect, liveness emerges as a new form of fidelity in bootleg recordings.

Isaac Blumfield

Harvard University

“The Speed of Samples: Audio Playback Speed as (Artistic) Research”

Manipulating the playback speed of audio samples is one of the earliest and simplest forms of transforming recordings. Its centrality to my own electronic music practice has prompted me to investigate its origins and widely varying applications across aesthetic and scientific fields, from its use in the identification of bat species, the “chopped and screwed” technique of DJ Screw and 1990’s Houston hip-hop, the sonification of earthquake data, and the genesis of the animated virtual band Alvin & the Chipmunks.

Drawing on the scholarship of Marcus Boon, Jonathan Sterne, and Kodwo Eshun, I explore how differing playback speed of samples fundamentally alters the perception of the sampled material on both the perceptual and affective levels. Through shifting ultrasonic and infrasonic material into the range human hearing, scientists are able to listen to data in new critical ways, expanding the boundaries of scientific audile technique; likewise, the speed manipulations of DJ Screw and Alvin & the Chipmunks allow listeners to perceive something radically other and

uncanny in familiar recordings, with both approaches (“screwing” and “chipmunking”) becoming highly influential in modern hip-hop, pop, and internet culture.

These examples each highlight the unique power of a seemingly simple technique, drawing attention to the ways in which the materiality of recording technology itself has shaped scientific knowledge and music production through the intertwined nature of sonic perception and affective listening. I conclude by briefly outlining the centrality of playback speed to my own electronic music practice, focusing on its ability to allow me to reimagine my own large self-recorded sample library.

Mike Clemow

Independent

“Audi Pro Nobis: Field Recording, Dysmorphia, and the Post-commodity Condition”

Field recording has always suffered a kind of identity dysmorphia — never quite resolving into music, never quite escaping music's shadow, perpetually misrecognized by the industry structures that surrounded it. It circulated at the margins of commerce as library content, ambient filler, or raw material, never fully achieving commodity status even when music was a commodity. Now that music isn't one either, field recording's chronic misidentification takes on new theoretical weight.

Drawing on Marek Poliks's diagnosis of music's migration from commodity to metadata — from a thing sold to a referential index serving algorithmic infrastructure — this paper asks what it means to have always been the thing that didn't quite make it into the category now being dissolved. Streaming platforms don't sell music; they sell algorithms that decide, on our behalf, what is worth hearing. This delegation of listening — what Robert Pfaller theorized as interpassivity, and what we have elsewhere called *audi pro nobis* — has reached its logical endpoint in the generative AI era, where automated systems not only curate but synthesize, not only recommend but replace. Field recording was prospected before it ever achieved the commodity status that would have made such prospecting legible as loss.

This paper builds on prior work co-authored with David Michael, presented at *In the Field* 2 (UAL, July 2024), in which we theorized “pressing stop” — creative refusal as ethical and methodological response to extractive field recording practices. Here, refusal is considered as a potentially clarifying lens on the post-commodity condition: a means of reclaiming not just agency over the practice, but the right to frame what the practice is and what it is for — against the distorting pressures of platforms, automation, and a music industry that never quite saw field recording clearly to begin with.

Panel #7: Twisting Narratives and Semiotics

Chair: David Samuels

(1:15 p.m. – 2:45 p.m., Silver 320)

Jardena Gertler-Jaffe

New York University

“Chronotopes of Jewish Persona in Bates’ *Kavalier and Clay*”

The Metropolitan Opera performed its commission of *The Amazing Adventures of Kavalier and Clay* on the Met stage in October 2025, returning in February 2026 after a sold-out initial run. *Kavalier and Clay*, adapted from Michael Chabon’s Pulitzer Prize-winning novel, is set at the beginning of WWII, first in Prague and, following Joseph Kavalier’s displacement to his cousin Sam Clay’s home, in New York. The story follows these Jewish cousins as they invent a comic-book superhero, “The Escapist,” a morale-boosting character who fights on behalf of Jews. To bring “authenticity to the subject matter,” composer Mason Bates spent six months at a reform temple in San Francisco, “immersing himself in the culture” to “integrate elements of what he heard into his music” (Metropolitan Opera “Master Key,” 2025).

I argue that this construction of authenticity fails to attend to the specificities of historical Jewish soundworlds. Treating opera as a multi-modal performance medium with layered semiotic processes, I track representations of difference in the opera through emblems of identity and alterity, marked language-in-use, and Jewish melodies (Agha 2005; Silverstein 2003, 2021; Labov 1972; Adelstein 2024). I contend that the representation of Jews in the opera can be understood as a chronotope that transposes ideologies from the present onto Prague and New York in 1939. Drawing on the live production, libretto, and promotional materials, I interrogate how Jewish representation was approached during production. Lastly, I explore a difficult question: What might Jewish difference sound and look like in 21st-century opera?

Ellen Jeon

New York University

“IMDb Sorting Algorithms and the Semiotics of Audience Voice in *Squid Game*”

Online platforms are often treated as transparent spaces where audience opinions are expressed and aggregated. However, this paper argues that platforms such as IMDb do not merely display reception but often distort it through mechanisms of sorting, visibility, and repetition. Taking *Squid Game* (2021) as a case study, this project examines how different review-ordering systems, specifically by comparing “featured” (most helpful) reviews and randomized user reviews, which produce distinct semiotic constructions of audience voice.

Drawing on semiotic theory, particularly concepts of entextualization and enregisterment, this paper shows that featured reviews are not simply more popular but are recontextualized as authoritative discourse. These reviews tend to be longer, more structured, and analytically oriented, performing a critic-like voice that resembles professional evaluation. Through repeated prominence, this style becomes enregistered as the normative form of legitimate audience reception. In contrast, randomized reviews foreground affect, fragmentation, and immediacy, consisting of shorter, emotionally driven responses that lack consistent structure or interpretive authority.

The contrast between these two sets of reviews reveals that audience reception is not a stable or pre-existing category but a semiotic effect produced by platform-specific regimes of visibility. IMDb's sorting system privileges certain forms of discourse while marginalizing others, effectively transforming a heterogeneous set of viewer responses into a coherent and hierarchical representation of "the audience." In this sense, platform design functions as a form of distortion, not simply misrepresenting reality, but actively shaping what counts as meaningful or legitimate interpretation.

By reframing audience reception as a product of semiotic mediation, this paper contributes to broader discussions of platform power, algorithmic visibility, and the cultural politics of digital media.

Zachary Walker-Kahne

Columbia Teachers College

"The False Promise of Music in Dorothy Baker's *Young Man with a Horn* (1938) and Michael Ondaatje's *Coming Through Slaughter* (1976)"

This paper examines the archetype of the tortured artist, here embodied in the form of the self-destructive jazz musician, in two novels that were inspired by the musical careers of historical figures: Dorothy Baker's *Young Man With a Horn* (1938), inspired by the music of cornetist Bix Beiderbecke, and Michael Ondaatje's *Coming Through Slaughter* (1976), a work of historiographic metafiction which imagines the life of cornetist Buddy Bolden. The doomed protagonists, one Black and the other white, seek liberation from their socially-defined identities through sonic expression. I argue that both novels expose the false promise of liberation in music through descriptions of sonic experience, poetics, and the process of reimagining lost sounds. Baker's novel shows how the auditory sense can be distorted by listening practices that categorize sound along what Jennifer Lynn Stoeber calls "the sonic color line." In Baker's story, these warped perceptions are revealed through acousmatic listening experiences afforded by emerging sound reproduction technologies such as the phonograph and the radio. Ondaatje's fragmented novel, which employs a more experimental narrative form, poetics, and creative use of blank space, mines the audible dimension of the text to highlight the problem of historical representation. The novel self-consciously grapples with its own failure to represent Bolden's life and music, which has been distorted by time, memory, and the author's own inscription of subjectivity. I link these texts to Saidiya Hartman's foundational work on critical fabulation and Fred Moten's concept of "the resistance of the object" to illustrate how, in both novels, jazz improvisation resists written representation and troubles western musical notation, as well as the recording process itself. Taken together, these novels present the world of twentieth-century jazz as one that exposes the arbitrary but highly regulated nature of existing social relations through its subversive approach to sound creation.

Panel #8: Political Spirals

Chair: Louis Karchin

(3:00 p.m. – 4:00 p.m., Silver 320)

Lydia Rufin

University of Kentucky

“Dancing With the Devil: Music and Dance as Indicators of Social Inversion in Images of the Witches’ Sabbath in Early Modern Europe”

Witchcraft scholarship has extensively recognized witchcraft as a system of oppositional representation of life. This paper demonstrates how inversion and disorder are translated as sensory experiences through the inclusion of rustic instruments and folk dances. I argue that music and dance in early modern witches’ sabbath images are the primary means by which inversion is implied. After examining the choreography and musical arrangements included in images from Johann Praetorius’ *Blockes-Berges Verrichtung* (1669) and Francesco Maria Guazzo’s *Compendium Maleficarum* (1608), I trace these elements back to their iconographic and historical origins within manuscript marginalia and accounts of festival celebration to trace the shift from the implied motion and noise of earlier witchcraft images—like those of Albrecht Durer—to clear demonstrations of heresy.

With Stuart Clark’s theory of inversion, I introduce the concept of social inversion as a sensory experience to describe the way images of discordant sound and ecstatic dance serve as inversions of communal and religious life. The noisy instruments chosen for these images include pipes, fiddles, and bagpipes, each of which have larger historical associations with rustic, bawdy music and grotesque excess. Meanwhile, the familiar circle dances of Saints’ Days are turned frantic and thus into scenes of ecstasy and compulsion, echoing the dance manias of earlier centuries. Using the work of Michael Camille and Emanuel Winternitz, I situate these instruments into a broader tradition of grotesque marginalia, while using the frameworks of Mikhail Bakhtin and Victor Turner to understand the inversion of communal festivity into carnivalesque misrule and ritual anti-structure.

By tracing the symbolic histories of music and dance, I ultimately argue that witches’ sabbath imagery reconfigures familiar practices into sign of demonic worship. The way that these images reframe these activities as distortions of early modern society through sound and movement reflect larger cultural anxieties around gender and social control surrounding the era of the Reformation Europe.

Winter Craig

Iowa State University

“Satanic Seal of Approval: The Parental Advisory Label’s Religious-Right Backmasking Scare Origins and Role in Democratic Campaign Strategies”

The Parental Advisory Label (PAL) for music has received consistent discussion on artistic censorship dynamics since its 1985 formulation, instigated by the Parents Music Resource Center (PMRC), due to the high-profile status of the politicians, campaigners, musicians, and industry executives involved, and has since inspired renewed scholarship analyzing the continued influence of stigmatizing labels on minority artists. Crucially, the inherent entertainment value of the

sensationalized 1985 Senate hearing debating the PMRC's labeling proposal and the perpetual lure of "censorship" topics has cut the full narrative short, ignoring the now-standardized PAL's origins in the first calls for legislated music ratings with overtly religious anti-backmasking bills that cropped up over the five preceding years. In analyzing the promotional materials of touring anti-rock crusaders through the early 1980s, in which they argued that rock musicians were intentionally hiding corruptive subliminal and "Satanic" secret messages in their songs that were only audible when the track was carefully played in reverse, and the foundational arguments for State bills that would require a warning label on albums containing backward masking, obvious influence on the PMRC's later fear-driven promotional tactics and rhetorical parallels are revealed. I argue that this timeframe expansion reframes the popularly assumed intent of the PAL as a mechanism to repress controversial artists instead as a means for liberal politicians (namely Al Gore and later both Bill and Hillary Clinton) to tap into family values polling in the height of the Reagan eighties without alienating their established voter base, challenging the contemporary conception of censorship as a purely restrictive force. The intentional distortion of physical recordings allowed crusaders to instill child safety panic-inducing interpretations of popular music in their followings, setting the stage for politicians to *promote* this fear and gain constituent support by offering a safety elixir in the form of the PAL.

Concert #2

(4:15 p.m. – 5:45 p.m., Silver 220)

Alma Laprida and Bryce Hackford

Subwoofer Duo

For a duration of 20 minutes, two players play one subwoofer each, spaced apart in the performance space, with one analog synthesizer each on either side of a table and the players seated at the table.

The compositional structure is conversational and the tuning structure is relational, with a lexicon built from the experience of working within the performance space. The sounds produced during this performance will create sympathy in mutually resonant materials such as furniture and bodies.

With this methodology we aim to bend, or warp, listening in both physically-performed and conceptual ways; how space and bodies are perceived in the context of a concert in Western music.

Alexandra Berger and Allen Fogelsanger

Static

A performance, by one dancer and one musician, of collaboratively choreographed real time movement/sound composing. Yes, we are improvising, but also listening--and conversing--and assembling a choreomusical structure shaped by and shaping time.

We offer a template suggested and described only by the title, "Static." The musician's instrumentation consists of a pair of skin reactive feedback synthesizers (with connected piezo disks), their outputs fed through separate comb filters and mixed within a laptop running the signal processing software Max. The resulting noise environment both surrounds, and as a contributor to movement, passes through, the dancer. The dancer's movement strategies expand beyond coordinating with timing and pitch, to include their sense of resonating with the sound. The space and duration of the performance set parameters. The relationships between and among the movement and sound materials provoke and provide emotional resonance as well.

While the sound of our performance is an obvious connection to the conference's theme, we would like to also emphasize that our collaborative improvisation is an equally notable, and more significant, connection. Messages pass between us, but simply because of the divergent media within which we each perform, there can be no perfectly replicated information. We may attempt to synchronize and correlate our respective visual and auditory outputs, but fail. We embrace this. We may purposefully distort each other's material, as well as our own upon repetition, producing variation, evolution, development--all forms of distortion with a positive valence. In "Static," distortion is a generator.

David Acevedo

NANO 1

NANO 1 is the first in a series of loop-based audio-visual works performed by myself, each of which is entirely derived from a very short sample—a nano-sample, as it were. In this iteration, the nano-sample is taken from the legendary Amen break, a seven-second drum break performed by Gregory Coleman as part of the Winstons’ 1969 song “Amen, Brother.”

Since it began to be sampled in the mid-1980s, the break has appeared in thousands of recordings and played a critical role in the development of entire EDM sub-genres such as jungle, drum and bass, and breakbeat, becoming one of the most recognizable samples in music history. In *NANO 1*, I subject this already ubiquitous fragment to another layer of fragmentation: breaking the break into even smaller chunks and manipulating them spontaneously. These sonic fragments simultaneously trigger hypnotic geometric patterns and fractured text in the projection, creating a visual counterpart to the continual distortion and recombination of the sound. Get lost in the dancing circles, and discover the familiar within the unfamiliar.

Laura Horne

To Which Do We Belong

In *The Order of Time*, Carlo Rovelli posits that time is not an absolute background, but a web of relational events. *To Which Do We Belong* treats this physical theory as an aesthetic methodology, investigating time not as a sequence, but as an object. By distorting the boundaries between personal memory, neurobiology, and global events, this work investigates how our perspective of the present is constructed through the interaction of disparate variables.

The performance utilizes the Korg Minilogue XD to create a sound environment where signals warp in respect to one another. Analog synthesis and granular processing mirror the neuro phenomenological distortion of time experienced during heightened states of consciousness. This sound is synchronized with a 20-minute visual projection exploring the domino effect of global resonance. Juxtaposing cultural motifs against shifting political currents and collective upheaval, this work illustrates the volatility of things happening in relation to each other.

Installations

Friday October 2nd and Saturday October 3rd
(Silver 120)

Bria Nachele

The Frick Collection

Bridge Over Troubled Watters / Still Watters Run Deep

(Ongoing installation, Friday October 2nd and Saturday October 3rd, 9am-5pm)

Bridge Over Troubled Watters / Still Watters Run Deep is a handmade speaker constructed from wood and repurposed audio components, featuring a redesigned floating tweeter array. Its form references an inherited Avon “Charisma” powder puff container passed down from the artist’s great-grandmother, Mary, merging personal ritual with sonic function. The work is named in honor of the artist’s maternal grandmother, Betty Jean Watters.

The speaker emits a layered audio composition drawn from intimate and regional archives: a 1984 cassette recording captured by the artist’s aunt and mother at ages 11 and 13 in Kokomo, Indiana on a Panasonic RX-F4 Stereo Cassette Recorder Boombox; a field recording from the artist’s great-aunt Chry’s funeral in 2024; and songs that situate Kokomo within the American popular music canon, including “Kokomo” by The Beach Boys, “First Snow in Kokomo” by Aretha Franklin, and “Kokomo Blues” by Scrapper Blackwell.

Together, these materials function as a multigenerational collaboration. By placing mythic and popular representations of Kokomo alongside familial archives of people from the town, the work reflects on the tension between folklore and lived reality within a rural Rust Belt landscape shaped by industrialization and factory labor. The work and research frames music as a form of folklore that has the power to reshape geographies, histories, and constructions of place, seeking to reclaim and re-situate overlooked or invisible people and narratives in rural Indiana within collective (sonic) memory and imagination.

The research culminates in the sound installation *Bridge Over Troubled Watters / Still Watters Run Deep*, a handmade speaker constructed from wood and repurposed audio components that extends my DJ and sonic practice. The work brings together a layered archival composition including a 1984 family recording from Kokomo captured by my aunt and mother at ages 13 and 11 on a Panasonic RX-F4 stereo cassette recorder boombox, a 2024 field recording from my great-aunt Chry’s funeral, and musical references that situate Kokomo within popular music history. Together, these materials form a multigenerational sonic archive that places mythic and popular representations of Kokomo in dialogue with familial memory and lived experience. Drawing on Karen Barad’s research on quantum entanglement alongside hauntological theory, the project frames sound as operating across space and time, where archival and familial recordings are understood as materially and temporally entangled rather than contained within linear history. Within this framework, music functions as a form of folklore that actively reshapes geography and historical narrative, while listening becomes a relational practice that engages inherited sonic and cultural worlds.

Sawyer Adler

CUNY Graduate Center

The Sunset Scrolls: An Opera for TikTok

(Screening, Friday October 2nd, 1:00 p.m., Silver 120)

The Sunset Scrolls is a series of 22 short-form vertical videos, designed to adhere to a novel set of aesthetic attributes taken directly from short-form video apps such as TikTok, Instagram Reels, and YouTube Shorts. Combining 'datamoshed' visuals with microtonal scoring, the opera features a series of nonlinear clips that deal opaquely with the role of technology in young people's lives, and critique the digital tropes and habits that characterize the very apps that deliver these types of short-form videos.

The opera is self-recursive — ending where it begins, referencing itself, and making use of nonlinear narrative (as the constituent clips can be viewed in any order). We engaged with this recursive, 'fractal' narrative and fragmentation of emotional center in an attempt to mimic the quirks and aberrances of the short-form media ecosystem: an ecosystem where sincerity is fleeting, and meaningful content is never more than a scroll away from content of interminable unimportance.

This opera maintains the historical 'aria-and-recitative' formal structure, but we have tried to let the traditional meanings of these terms mutate and self-destruct. In this opera, "entr'actes" form the bulk of the material, and the rare moments of sincerity and tenderness are found only in five diegetic songs that act as corrupted arias: arias that break away from the stupid, hacky one-liner nonsense of the entr'actes and attempt to speak some truth — whatever it may be — to the listener. In historical opera, entr'actes tend to be unimportant, 'filler' material, and I feel that there is nothing more fitting to form the bulk of an 'Opera For TikTok' than this same kind of material, now reveling in the sheer enormity of its own unimportance.

Keynote Performance: Ka Baird

Friday October 2nd at 7:00 p.m.
(Silver 220)

Ka Baird

Performer, Sound Artist, Musician, and Composer



Ka Baird is a performer, sound artist, musician and composer based in New York City. Using extended voice and microphone techniques along with electronics, feedback, field recordings, and flutes, they explore the outer dimensions of sound through performance. They create a present tense sound with a vigorous, ritualistic delivery that seeks extreme release through physical exertion and psychic extension. They have collaborated with many other artists, both in structured compositions and through their dedicated practice of improvisation.

Their solo releases include “Sapropelic Pycnic” (Drag City 2017), “Respires” (RVNG Intl 2019), “Brooding Exercises” (Longform Editions 2021), “Vivification Exercises” (RVNG Intl 2021) and “Bearings: Soundtracks for the Bardos” (RVNG 2024). Recent national and international engagements have included performances at Unsound (Krakow, PL), Rewire (The Hague, NL), Intonal (Malmo, SE), Lampo (Chicago, IL), Museum of Contemporary Art (Chicago, IL), MoMA PS1 (Queens, NY), Issue Project Room (Brooklyn, NY), The Kitchen (NYC), The Institute of Contemporary Art (Philadelphia, PA), TUSK Festival (Newcastle, UK), KRAAK (Brussels, BE), and Le Guess Who (Utrecht, NL). They have been artist-in-residence at We Jazz Festival (Helsinki, FI), Sonoscopia (Porto, PT), Inkons (Malmo, SE), Experimental Sound Studio (Chicago, IL), and Pioneer Works (Brooklyn, NY). They have been a recipient of the Foundation of Contemporary Art's Emergency Grant, a Jerome Foundation Artist-In-Residence at Roulette Intermedium, and a Jerome Hill Artist Fellow through 2023-25. They are one of the core members of Spires That In The Sunset Rise, founded in Chicago in 2001.

Keynote Lecture: Mara Mills

Saturday October 3rd at 6:00 p.m.
(Silver 320)

Mara Mills

Associate Professor of Media, Culture, and Communication, New York University



Mara Mills is Associate Professor of Media, Culture, and Communication at New York University and Director of the NYU Center for Disability Studies, a hub for public humanities and disability arts programming. At CDS, she is currently coordinating the Mellon-funded project ASAP: Access for Small Arts Partnerships. She is most recently coeditor of the collections *How to be Disabled in a Pandemic* (NYU Press, 2025), winner of the 2026 Foundation for the Sociology of Health and Illness Book Prize, and *Crip Authorship: Disability as Method* (NYU Press, 2023), a 2024 CHOICE Outstanding Academic Title. With Michele Friedner, she is currently editing a collection of historical and ethnographic essays titled "The Global Cochlear Implant," funded by an NEH Dangers and Opportunities of Technology grant. And she is completing a book coauthored with Jonathan Sterne on the history, aesthetics, and politics of time stretching technology, to be previewed as a podcast series produced by Benjamin Walker. She is also a founding editorial board member of the journal *Catalyst: Feminism, Theory, Technoscience*.

Venue and Accessibility

The Distortions Conference will take place on New York University's Washington Square campus, at the Silver Center for Arts and Sciences (Rooms 120, 220, and 320). The Silver Center can be accessed from both 31 Washington Place and 32 Waverly Place. The Waverly Place entrance is closest to our registration desk (Room 120).

Wi-Fi

To use NYU's guest wifi network, please follow these instructions:

1. On your device, select the wireless network called "nyuguest" from the list of available networks.
2. Open a web browser and go to any web page. The browser will be automatically redirected to the nyuguest login page.
3. Log in with the event guest username and password available at the conference registration desk in Silver 120.

Conference Accessibility

If you have any concerns about being able to participate leading up to and during the conference for any reason, please let the conference organizers and/or any nearby volunteers know!

Inclusive Restroom Facilities

A single-stall non-gendered restroom is available on the third floor of the Silver Center.

Building Access Information

The Silver Center (31 Washington Pl) should be accessible for those with mobility impairments. The conference committee is working to confirm functioning automatic door openers and available wheelchair accessible bathrooms. Of the Silver Center's two entrances (one on Washington Place and one on Waverly Place), the Waverly Place entrance is closest to our event but has several steps plus an uneven lip due to construction and may provide difficulties to those with mobility concerns. Both entrances are directly near elevators. All conference rooms will have reserved spaces for wheelchair users.

Program Accessibility

If a paper program would be helpful to you in terms of accessibility, do not hesitate to let one of our conference volunteers know and we will provide you with a paper copy.

Distortions Conference Organizers

Conference Co-Chairs

Hannah Krasikov
Christine Oppedisano
Yuval Tessman-Bar-On

Faculty Advisor

Clifton Boyd

Committee Members and Volunteers

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Bailey Hilgren
Chase Elodia
Chris Copley
Claire McMahan
Elizabeth Frickey
Jenn Grossman
Jessica Hallock
Rosie Kaplan
Trevor Van Velde
Will Martin

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